Chiwire Maps 4: Safety and Emergencies

What to do when something goes wrong in the Spanish mountains, and how the device helps. Procedures and organisations change: check the official sources linked here before each season.

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Call 112

112 is the emergency number in Spain and the whole European Union. It is free, and it connects you to the regional emergency centre, which sends the right service (mountain rescue, ambulance, fire brigade, police).

- **No coverage from your own operator?** A phone can call 112 through any operator's network that reaches it, even without your SIM's coverage.
- **Automatic location (AML).** Modern smartphones send their position to the 112 centre automatically during the call. It may not work without a SIM or without data, so **always say your position out loud** as well.
- **Low battery?** Call early, while you still have battery and light. Then switch the phone off between calls and agree a call-back time.
- **Only a weak signal?** Move higher or to an open spot, and try again.

What to say:

1. **What happened:** "a fall", "lost", "a hiker can't walk".
2. **Where:** your UTM position from the device, and the place name (see below).
3. **How many people,** and the injuries: conscious or not, breathing, bleeding, can walk.
4. **The terrain and the weather:** a path, a gully, snow, fog, wind, how much daylight is left.

5. **Your phone number,** and keep the line free afterwards.

Answer the questions, and don't hang up until they tell you to.

The dongle's Wi-Fi only reaches the phones nearby. It can't send messages or call for help.

Giving your position from the device

1. Stay still and let the GPS settle. The Source row must say 📍 `GPS` with several satellites. If it says `✛ Map center`, press 📍 **Me** first: otherwise the numbers are the map centre, not where you are.
2. Read the **UTM** row slowly, digit by digit, with the zone: "zone thirty T, four four zero, two nine zero; four four seven four, two five seven".
3. Give the **latitude and longitude** from the next row too, in decimal: "forty point four one six eight north, three point seven zero three eight west". Rescue services use both.
4. Say the **accuracy** shown in the Source row (for example `±8 m`), and the **altitude** if it is shown.
5. Add a **place name**: the nearest peak, refuge, village or path, from the map or the 🔍 search.
6. Ask them to read the numbers back to you.

Write the position on paper too, in case the phone or the dongle stops.

Who comes to the rescue

Mountain rescue in Spain depends on the region. 112 always decides who comes; you don't need to know in advance. For reference:

- **Guardia Civil:** its mountain rescue groups (GREIM, Grupos de Rescate Especial de Intervención en Montaña) work across most of Spain, often with a helicopter. The Guardia Civil's own number is **062**.
- **Catalonia and Navarre:** rescue is mostly done by the regional fire services' specialist teams.
- **Other regions** have their own teams too, all coordinated through 112.

Who pays. Rescue is normally free. Some regions (for example Cantabria, Asturias, Navarre and Catalonia) can bill the person rescued when the rescue was caused by recklessness, such as ignoring a closure or a warning. A **mountain federation licence** (through FEDME or your regional federation) includes accident and rescue insurance. Check its current cover before you rely on it.

Signals without a phone

International mountain distress signal: give **6 signals a minute** (whistle blasts, torch flashes, waves of a bright cloth), one every 10 seconds. Wait a minute, then repeat. The answer is **3 signals a minute**. Carry a whistle; it carries much farther than your voice and uses no energy.

Signals to a helicopter:

Signal	Meaning
Both arms raised in a **Y**	Yes, we need help
One arm raised, one arm down, as in an **N**	No, we don't need help

When a helicopter comes close: secure loose clothing, backpacks and anything the rotor wind could lift. Protect your eyes. Don't approach it until the crew signals you to, and then only from the front, in their sight.

Safe points

Know where the nearest safe points are before you go, and mark them with 🚩 **Marks**:

- **Shelters and refuges:** search for "refugio" or the refuge's name, or turn on the "Points of interest" layer (🛖 icons). Staffed refuges have a guard in season; unstaffed shelters may be locked or in poor condition.
- **Villages, roads and car parks:** the easiest places for a rescue team to reach.
- **Water points:** 💧 in the search and the points of interest. In summer, springs can dry up.
- **Emergency services and hospitals:** 🚒 and 🏥 in the search.

The points of interest come from OpenStreetMap: they can be missing, misplaced or out of date. Confirm critical ones on an official map or with the park or refuge.

Weather and avalanches

Weather. Check the forecast the evening before and the morning you leave. The Spanish weather agency AEMET publishes mountain forecasts for the main ranges: aemet.es mountain forecast. Watch for:

- **Summer storms:** they often build up in the afternoon. Start early, and get off ridges and peaks before they arrive. During lightning, avoid summits, ridges, lone trees and metal, and crouch on your pack on lower ground.
- **Wind:** strong wind makes ridges dangerous and cools you fast (wind chill).
- **Fog:** it removes all landmarks; see guide 3.
- **Heat:** on the meseta and in the south, carry more water than you think and avoid the middle of the day.

Avalanches. In winter and spring, read the avalanche bulletin before going into snow-covered terrain. It rates the danger from 1 (low) to 5 (very high):

- **AEMET** publishes the avalanche danger bulletin for the Pyrenees of Navarre and Aragón, the Catalan Pyrenees, the Picos de Europa, the Sierra de Guadarrama and other ranges, usually from December to May.

- **The Catalan Cartographic and Geological Institute (ICGC)** publishes the avalanche bulletin for the Catalan Pyrenees, Monday to Saturday in season.

Avalanche terrain needs training and equipment (transceiver, probe, shovel). The device can't tell you whether a slope is safe.

Before you go

- **Leave an itinerary** with someone you trust: the route, the start and end points, the car's location, the number of people, and the time by which they should call 112 if they haven't heard from you.
- **Check in** at the agreed times, when you have coverage.
- **Carry:** a paper map and compass, a whistle, a headlamp, a spare power bank, warm and waterproof layers, food and water, a first aid kit, and a survival blanket.
- **Charge** the power bank and the phone fully. Test the device at home: the map, the layers you need, the GPS fix outdoors.

First aid

This guide gives no medical advice. Learn first aid from an official course, for example with the Spanish Red Cross, and follow the instructions of the 112 operator during an emergency. Carry a basic first aid kit and know how to use what's in it.

Protected natural areas

National and natural parks have their own rules, which vary by region and change over time: camping and bivouac rules, access limits and permits, fires, drones, dogs, closed areas during breeding seasons. Check the official website of the park or the regional government before you go. Ignoring a closure can also make you pay for your own rescue (see Who comes to the rescue).